The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump warned that America would destroy **Iran's** "bridges next, then electric power plants". Earlier on Thursday America's main oil benchmark rose to its highest level since mid-2022 after Mr Trump threatened to hit Iran "extremely hard". Separately, Pete Hegseth, the secretary of war, reportedly dismissed **Randy George**, the army's chief of staff. It is highly unusual to fire a general during wartime.

Mr Trump sacked **Pam Bondi**, America's attorney-general. Over the past 14 months, Ms Bondi has overseen the **Department of Justice's** failed attempts to prosecute the president's enemies. Mr Trump was also reportedly displeased with her handling of the Epstein files. Calling her a "loyal friend", Mr Trump said that Todd Blanche, her deputy, would serve as acting attorney-general.

Mr Trump unveiled **tariffs** of up to 100% on some branded drugs, targeting **pharmaceutical companies** that have not lowered prices or increased manufacturing in America. Generic medicines will be exempt. At the same time, his administration eased tariffs on products that contain small amounts of steel, aluminium or copper, and simplified how those duties are calculated.

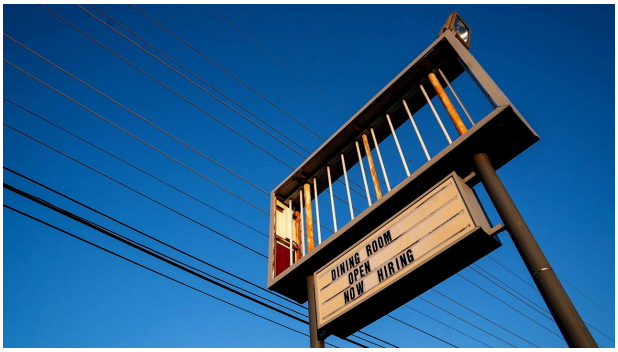
Russia launched large air strikes across Ukraine, according to the Ukrainian air force. The attacks, which involved more than 400 drones and ten ballistic missiles, showed that the Russians were adopting “new tactics” by continuing raids into daytime hours, officials said. The governor of Kharkiv, an eastern region, said one person had been killed and a further 25 injured.

Myanmar’s parliament appointed Min Aung Hlaing, the head of the ruling junta, as the country’s president. The junta controls the legislature after a recent sham election. Since taking power in a coup in 2021, Min Aung Hlaing has lost control of much of the country in a violent uprising. He has formally stepped down from the army to become president, but has passed military power to an ally.

Italy’s government extended a tax cut on fuel until the beginning of May because of the Iran war’s impact on energy prices. The measure reduces the price of petrol and diesel by $0.29 per litre; the extension is expected to cost around €500m ($577m) in total. Other governments are considering energy bail-outs: this week France’s prime minister said he was in favour of “targeted aid”.

French police tightened security at sites across Paris after foiling a bomb attack at the **Bank of America’s** headquarters in the capital last week. Other American banks allowed staff to temporarily work from home. Authorities have placed four people under formal investigation. They said suspects may be linked to Harakat Ashab al-Yamin al-Islamiyya, a pro-Iranian Islamist group that had threatened an attack on social media.

Figure of the day: 13 points, the average lead that the opposition Tisza party enjoys over Viktor Orban’s Fidesz ahead of Hungary’s election on April 12th, according to independent and opposition-allied polls. Read the full story.



Photograph: Getty Images

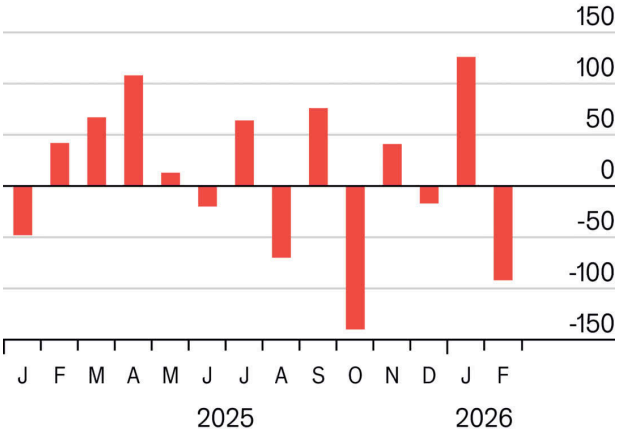
America’s hiring freeze

Last year America’s jobs market lurched from strong to unsteady—and back again. Troubling months of payroll data were followed by reassuring ones. That volatility has largely carried on in 2026. January brought a surprisingly high number of new hires; February a low number. Conventional wisdom holds that America’s jobs market is stuck in a “low-hire, low-fire” funk: a healthy economy means little reason for layoffs (AI scares aside), but uncertain trade policies and a glum economic mood are deterring hiring, too.

Until last month, that jobs shakiness could well have nudged the Federal Reserve to cut interest rates. Even if Jerome Powell, the current chair, looked reluctant, his successor, Kevin Warsh, won Donald Trump’s nomination in large part by calling forcefully for cuts. Then the president started bombing Iran. With oil prices surging and worries about inflation mounting, cuts are probably off the table for now. Markets are pricing in 82% probability that interest rates will remain unchanged this year.

Peaks and valleys

United States, non-farm payrolls, change on previous month, '000



Source: Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis

Photograph: Getty Images

Kalshi’s high-stakes battle

America’s largest prediction-market site will need Lady Luck on its side when it grapples with two legal challenges against it on Friday. In Nevada, a court will decide whether to ban Kalshi, which offers sport, entertainment and election contracts, from operating in the state. In Arizona, where the firm faces criminal charges for running an “illegal gambling operation”, a judge will consider Kalshi’s plea for a federal court to block the case. Kalshi has called the charges “meritless”.

These are the latest clashes in a showdown between the marketplace and more than a dozen state regulators who want to bring the firm under their jurisdiction and subject it to local taxes. They argue that underneath the financial-market gloss, Kalshi is as much a gambling arena as any frontier saloon bar.

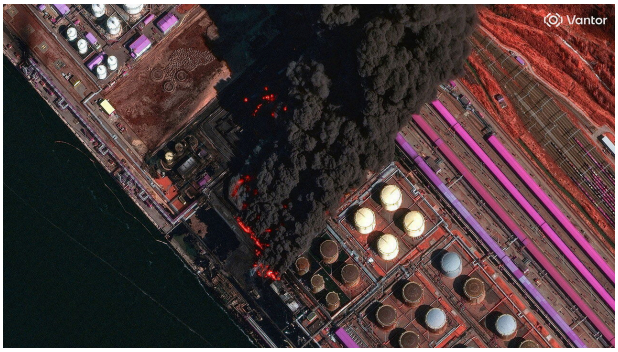
Kalshi is regulated by the Commodity Futures Trading Commission, a federal body overseeing futures and other derivatives. The firm has argued that this should trump state laws. Perhaps this will be the ace up its sleeve.

Photograph: Getty Images

Caracas after Maduro

There is a surreal feeling to Caracas, Venezuela's capital. Three months after the United States abducted Nicolás Maduro, the authoritarian president, the same regime (minus its head) is all hugs and handshakes with the Americans in town—who partly run the country. Giant photos of the former dictator hang over the motorways, and yet almost no one mentions him. Former political prisoners speak nervously about their experiences. Around 700 have been granted amnesty, but charges hang over many.

Amid the oddness and the misery, there is optimism. Members of Vente Venezuela, an opposition party, gather to discuss elections the organisers believe could be held in nine months. "This is the moment," one woman insists. Meanwhile in the plush Caracas Country Club, businesspeople are more cautious: the economy's prospects look brighter under the American-backed regime, they reason, so why risk the instability of an election so soon? The regime will want to play for time. Venezuelans may not be so patient.



Photograph: Reuters

Russia’s short-lived oil bonanza

Russia’s finance ministry will publish its monthly oil- and gas-revenue figures for March on Friday. The numbers are likely to show a surge. The value of Russian oil exports is estimated to have doubled in the first three weeks of the month, as the war in Iran pushed crude above $100 a barrel and America temporarily eased some restrictions on Russian oil. Asian buyers, eager for supply, quickly stepped in. But the real windfall may come later: in April government oil and gas revenues are expected to reach around 0.9trn roubles ($11bn), the highest since October.

The boom may prove short-lived. Last week the Kremlin admitted it would be “difficult” to continue to meet such demand after Ukrainian drone strikes knocked out roughly 40% of Russia’s oil-export capacity. To prioritise domestic supply, the government has banned gasoline exports.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which American President pardoned Richard Nixon?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

The really frightening thing about middle age is the knowledge that you'll grow out of it.

Doris Day